

One of Those Girls

“They soar like birds,”
the announcer's voice echoes,
smooth and steady,
as I watch those girls on the screen—
flipping and spinning through the air.
Each leap defies gravity,
their bodies wrapped in sparkling leotards,
movements delicate as feathers,
yet powerful as wind.

I want to soar too.
I want to dance through the air,
like them.
I want to flip, twirl, and reshape the wind.

I ask my mama if I can be one of those girls.

She hands me a karate belt instead,
telling me I need to learn how to protect myself.
Gone are the dreams of vibrant leotards
that represent my country.
In their place, stiff uniforms,
that represent my rank.
Instead of flying,
I am grounded,
learning to punch, kick, block.
There's no soaring here.

I feel less like one of those girls,
more like a child trapped
in a nightmare of broken boards,
tight fists, and colored belts.
Each strike digs me deeper
into a sport that doesn't fit.
A sport that clips my wings.

I reject karate.

My mama releases me from that world,
only to throw me into the world of softball.
She thinks this sport is easy—
something kids can handle.
Now, I wear a helmet, hold a bat,

my feet stuck in the dirt.
There's no place for flight here.
I swing but long for the feeling
of soaring.

At last, she tries basketball,
a sport my mama loves.
Here my body is pushed
to move fast but never freely.
I bounce and dribble,
but it feels heavy,
a far cry from the weightlessness
of those girls in flight.
I am pulled further and further
away from those girls,
their world of leaps and bounds,
a world I'll never touch.

With each game, the passion of sport dims.
My love begins to dissolve,
not suddenly,
but like sugar under warm water—
slowly vanishing,
losing its form until nothing was left
but the bittersweet ache.

Now, I don't even turn to my TV
when gymnastics competitions come on.
I act like it doesn't exist—
but deep down, I still feel it,
the longing
because I will never be

one of those girls.